



TIMES HIGHER EDUCATION

Universities Ranking Analysis

Identifying patterns in global higher education performance and surfacing strategic insights for institutions and policymaker

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Aim and Context

Universities play a major role in shaping research, innovation, economic growth, and global talent development. The Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2026 dataset provides detailed information on how universities across the world perform across key academic and institutional indicators. This analysis aims to examine and compare university performance using metrics such as teaching, research, citations, industry income, and international outlook. It also explores how institutional characteristics, including student population, student–staff ratio, and international student representation, relate to overall rankings and performance. Through statistical analysis and data visualizations, the study identifies country-level trends, relationships between ranking metrics, and broader patterns within global higher education systems.

Data Overview

2191
Ranked Institutions

5
Scoring Dimensions

90+
Countries

The dataset has been scraped from the Times Higher Education website.

The scoring of all institutions done on teaching, research, citations, international outlook and industry income.

The dataset has been preprocessed before the analysis for cleaner results.

This analysis has been conducted for the institutions to understand the area of improvements.

Methodology

Data Preprocessing : Dropped irrelevant metadata columns, parsed comma-formatted student counts & percentage strings to numeric types, and resolved range scores (e.g. "56.4–58.6") to midpoints, ensuring a clean, analysis-ready dataset across 2,191 institutions.

Data Standardisation : Columns were regrouped into logical tiers (identity → scores → stats → dimensions) with uniform float casting across all five metric scores and consistent naming conventions applied throughout.

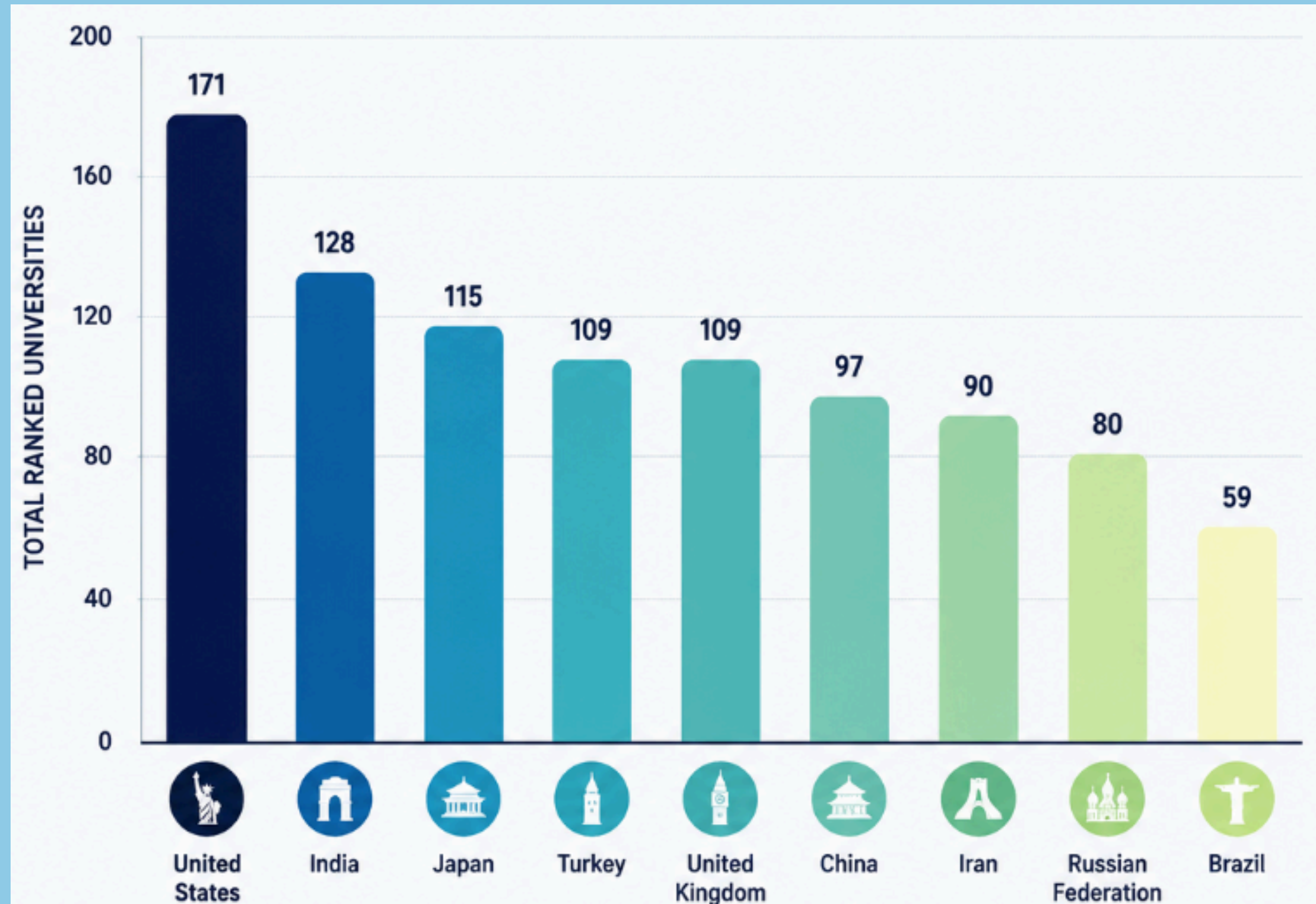
Visualisations : Six chart types (bar, range-scatter, radar, histogram, scatter, heatmap) were used to surface patterns across both country-level systems and individual institution profiles.

Top Countries Overview

RANK	UNIVERSITY	COUNTRY	OVERALL SCORE ★	STUDENT & DIVERSITY STATS				PILLAR SCORES (OUT OF 100)										OVERALL RANK 👑
				NO. OF STUDENTS	STUDENT- STAFF RATIO	% INT'L STUDENTS	FEMALE : MALE RATIO	TEACHING 📖		RESEARCH 🧪		CITATIONS “		INDUSTRY INCOME 💼		INTERNATIONAL OUTLOOK 🌐		
1	 University of Oxford	 United Kingdom	98.2	22,005	10.4 : 1	43.0%	52 : 48	97.2	4	100.0	2	97.7	12	99.9	50	96.4	23	1
2	 Massachusetts Institute of Technology	 United States	97.7	11,703	7.7 : 1	33.0%	43 : 57	99.2	1	95.3	11	99.6	1	100.0	15	91.9	97	2
3	 Princeton University	 United States	97.2	8,739	8.2 : 1	23.0%	47 : 53	98.2	2	97.3	9	99.0	4	98.0	112	85.4	196	3
4	 University of Cambridge	 United Kingdom	97.2	21,045	11.3 : 1	38.0%	50 : 50	96.2	6	99.9	3	97.1	19	87.6	231	96.3	24	4
5	 Stanford University	 United States	97.1	17,422	5.9 : 1	25.0%	48 : 52	97.5	3	97.4	8	99.5	2	100.0	25	83.9	215	5

- The top universities observed in the list were from UK and US in majority.

Top Countries Overview



- Countries like US, India and Japan are the top contributors to the Top Ranking Universities.

Top Countries Overview

COUNTRY	AVERAGE STUDENT-TO-STAFF RATIO (Lower is Better)	AVERAGE STUDENT POPULATION (Number of Students)
 Singapore	 19.15 Higher Ratio	 30,708.50 Larger Population
 United Kingdom	 17.26 Lower Ratio	 19,486.47 Moderate Population
 United States	 14.20 Lowest Ratio (Best)	 23,740.13 Large Population

- Singapore, despite having 2 universities, is having more student to staff ratio and student population and is still performing well, showing its unbiasedness.

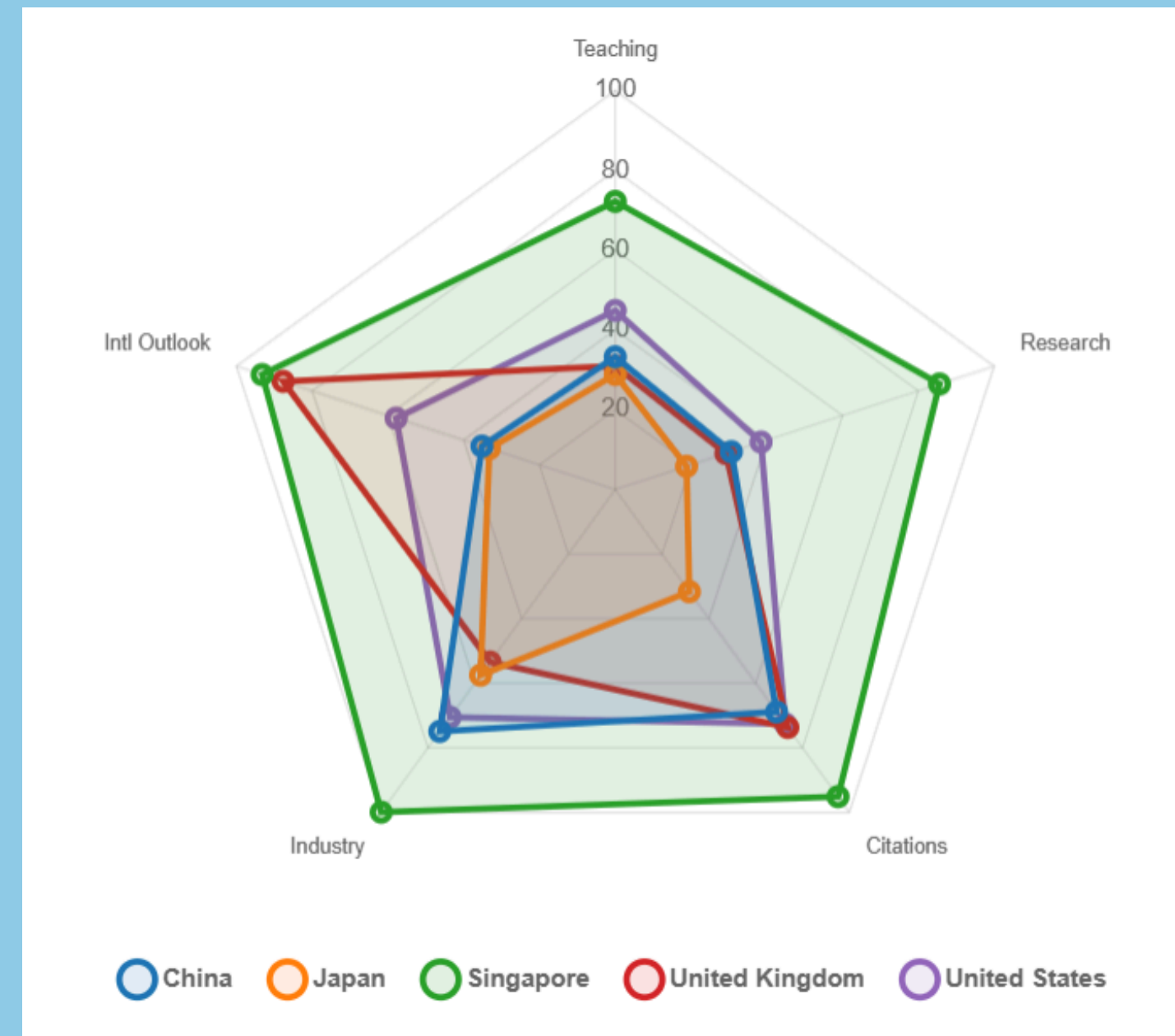
Top Countries Overview

- The top 10 universities observed in the list were from UK and US.
- Countries like US, India and Japan are the top contributors to the Top Ranking Universities
- Singapore is handling 2 universities, with both having similar scores and gets the lowest variation in the scores of all its universities.
- US and UK have 100+ universities with millions of students and are suffering with poor average scores



Top Countries Overview

- Singapore scores consistently high across Teaching, Research, Citations, Industry, and International Outlook, which suggests a concentrated, high-quality university ecosystem.
- Singapore demonstrates a smaller but highly optimized and globally integrated higher education system, whereas Japan has a larger university ecosystem but comparatively lower international and research performance efficiency.
- US and UK dominate the top tier of global rankings, showing strong performance especially in research and citations, even if their scores are less uniform than Singapore's.
- Countries like the US, India, and Japan have many ranked universities, but the chart suggests that having more institutions does not guarantee stronger average performance across all metrics.



Advantages and Trade Off

Advantages

- US and UK are contributing well in the top ranking universities showing their good management and seriousness towards academics and research.

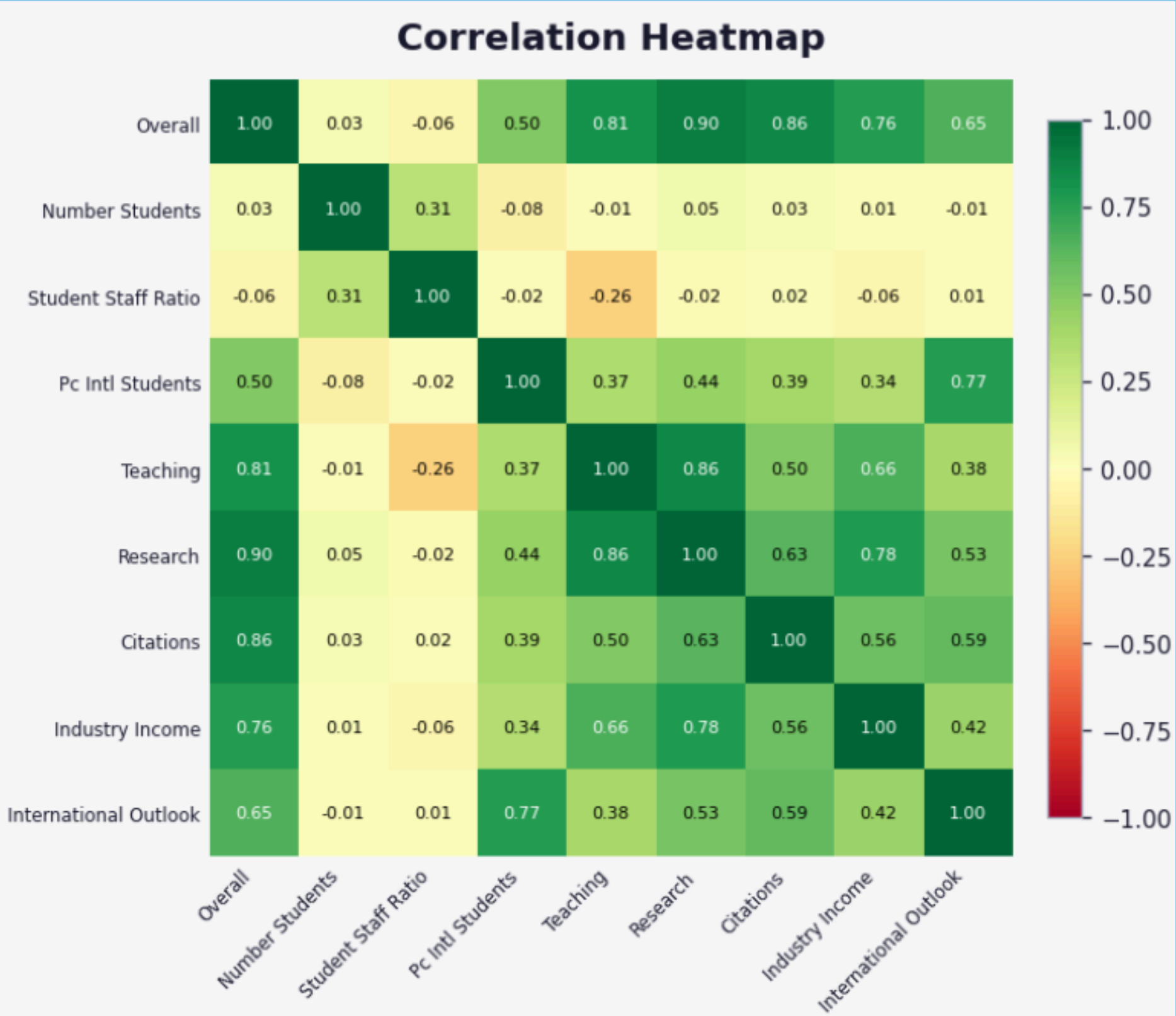
- Singapore is having more student to staff ratio and student population and is still performing well, showing its good management.

Trade-offs

- US and UK show significant spread between their best and worst scorers, pointing to systemic inequality within national higher education.

- US and UK universities have low student to staff ratio and student population and still unable to improve the average score.

An Analysis of Who Influences What?



An Analysis of Who Influences What?

- **Teaching with Research**

High teaching performance almost always coexists with strong research output, indicating shared institutional quality rather than separate strengths.

- **Research with Industry Income**

Research strength often supports industry collaboration, but real-world conversion depends on applied focus and external partnerships.

- **International Students with International Outlook**

Higher international student presence aligns with stronger international outlook scores, reflecting global integration effects on ranking perception.

- **Student–Staff Ratio with Teaching**

Higher student load slightly reduces teaching quality due to diluted attention and resource strain.

Key Takeaways

The current focus should be to upgrade the scores of these pre existing universities, to help them grow and upskill the students.

Defining upper limits on student intake at the institutional level can prevent quality dilution as student numbers grow. Interviewing them is the best way possible to understand and decide.

Actively recruiting international students and faculty is not merely a diversity initiative — it has measurable impact on overall performance scores.

Maintaining a smaller, elite set of universities with strong international outlook and concentrated research investment is a replicable model for any country willing to prioritise depth over breadth.

Reducing the student-to-staff ratio is one of the most actionable and measurable levers available to improve both teaching scores and overall rankings.

Conclusion

The analysis of the Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2026 reveals that global university excellence is strongly influenced by research quality, teaching performance, international engagement, and industry collaboration. Countries such as the United States and the United Kingdom continue to dominate global rankings due to their strong academic and research ecosystems, while Singapore demonstrates how focused investment and international integration can produce exceptional results despite limited population and geographical size.

The study also shows that having a larger number of universities does not always guarantee stronger average performance. Metrics such as citations, research strength, and international outlook exhibit strong relationships with overall university scores, highlighting the importance of global collaboration and research impact in modern higher education systems. Additionally, lower student–staff ratios show a moderate positive influence on teaching quality and institutional performance.

Overall, the findings suggest that sustainable academic excellence depends not only on scale, but also on strategic investment, research efficiency, global connectivity, and institutional quality.



Thank you!

Feedback and Questions are welcome.